Jane Eyre

A simplified retelling

Original story by Charlotte Brontë

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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A simplified retelling

Original story by Charlotte Brontë. Abridged and retold in modern English for Speak Boldly.

This edition keeps the main story, characters and ending. It is a retelling, not the complete original novel. The language is aimed at intermediate learners. Read a little at a time. You do not need to understand every word to follow Jane's journey.

The story includes unkind treatment, illness, death and a house fire. These events are described without graphic detail.

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1. A place where I did not belong

My name is Jane Eyre. When I was a child, I lived at Gateshead with my aunt, Mrs Reed, and her three children. My parents were dead. My uncle had taken me into his home, but he had died too. Before his death, he had asked his wife to care for me.

Aunt Reed gave me food and a place to sleep, but she did not love me. Her daughters, Eliza and Georgiana, often ignored me. Her son, John, was cruel. He reminded me that I had no money and that the house did not belong to me.

On a cold afternoon, I hid behind a curtain with a book. Reading helped me forget the house around me. Then John found me.

“You have no right to take our books,” he said.

He threw the book at me. It hurt, and I was frightened. But this time, I answered him. I was tired of being silent when he treated me badly.

The servants came. They saw us fighting and took John's side. Aunt Reed ordered them to lock me in the red

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room.

That was the room where my uncle had died. I begged them to let me go somewhere else. Nobody listened.

Inside the room, the furniture looked strange in the weak light. I thought about my uncle. Would he be angry that nobody had kept the promise to care for me? I became so frightened that I cried out. After that, I remembered very little.

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2. Leaving Gateshead

When I woke, I was in bed. Bessie, one of the servants, was beside me. Sometimes she was impatient, but she could also be kind. A man called Mr Lloyd had come to see how I was feeling.

He asked if I was happy at Gateshead. I told him the truth. I was not.

“Would you like to go to school?” he asked.

I did not know much about schools. Still, the idea of leaving Gateshead gave me hope.

Later, Mr Brocklehurst visited the house. He was in charge of a school for girls called Lowood. Aunt Reed told him that I was a difficult child who could not be trusted. I listened with a hot, angry face. I wanted him to know that she was wrong.

After he left, I spoke to my aunt. My voice shook, but I did not stop.

“I am not a liar,” I told her. “You have been unkind to me.”

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For the first time, I had said clearly what I felt. Afterwards, I was not only proud. I was also sad. I was a lonely child, and I still wanted someone to love me.

Soon, my journey to Lowood began. It was early and dark when I left. Bessie helped me get ready. The road was long, and I was too young to know what waited at the other end.

I hoped the school would give me something that Gateshead had never given me: a place where I could belong.

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3. Cold mornings at Lowood

Lowood was not the warm, happy place I had imagined. The rooms were cold. We got up early, washed in cold water and ate simple food. Some mornings, the food was burnt or there was not enough.

Many girls had no family to care for them. We wore plain clothes and followed strict rules. Mr Brocklehurst said we should learn to live with very little. Yet when his family visited, their fine clothes told a different story.

Not everyone at Lowood was unkind. Miss Temple, one of the teachers, spoke gently and noticed when we were hungry or tired. I began to trust her.

I also met Helen Burns. She was older than I was and loved books. A teacher often criticised her, but Helen did not answer angrily.

“Why do you let her speak to you like that?” I asked.

Helen explained that she did not want to fill her life with hate. I found this difficult to understand. When someone hurt me, I wanted to fight back.

“You can remember the people who are kind to you,”

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she said.

I did remember. I remembered Miss Temple's face and Helen's quiet voice. For the first time, I had a friend who listened to me.

The days were still hard. My hands were cold, and I was often hungry. But I had begun to learn. Books, lessons and friendship gave me small reasons to look forward to the next morning.

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4. A friend I never forgot

One day, Mr Brocklehurst made me stand in front of the school. He repeated Aunt Reed's words and warned the other girls not to trust me.

I felt as if everyone was looking at me. I could not explain myself. When I was finally allowed to leave, I went away and cried.

Helen found me. She did not believe I was a bad child. Later, Miss Temple listened to my story. She checked what I had told her and made it clear that the accusation against me was unfair. The shame I had felt began to lift.

In spring, a serious fever spread through Lowood. Many girls became ill. People outside the school began to ask questions about the poor food, cold rooms and unhealthy conditions.

Helen was ill too, but she had a different disease. She grew weaker while the weather outside became warmer. I wanted to believe that she would recover.

One night, I went to her room. I climbed into bed beside her and held her.

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“Are you frightened?” I asked.

She spoke quietly and tried to comfort me. Even then, she was thinking about someone else's fear.

I fell asleep beside my friend. When I woke, Helen had died.

I never forgot her. Lowood changed after people learned what had happened there. Conditions improved, and life became healthier for the girls. I stayed, studied hard and eventually became a teacher. But part of my education had come from Helen: a lesson in friendship that no book could replace.

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5. A door opens

I spent eight years at Lowood: six as a pupil and two as a teacher. I learned many things, and Miss Temple helped me become more confident. When she married and left the school, I felt that an important part of my life had changed.

I was grateful for my education. Still, I wanted to see more of the world. The same rooms, roads and daily duties no longer felt enough.

I put an advertisement in a newspaper. I offered to teach a child in a private home. Soon, a reply arrived from Mrs Fairfax at a house called Thornfield Hall.

The position was for a governess: a woman who lived with a family and taught a child. I accepted it.

Before I left, Bessie came to visit. She told me news of Gateshead. I was happy to see a familiar face, but I did not wish to return to my old life.

The journey to Thornfield was long. When I arrived, Mrs Fairfax welcomed me kindly. She was the housekeeper, not the owner, as I had first imagined.

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My pupil was Adèle, a lively girl who had come from France. She liked singing, dancing and talking. I would need patience, but I was pleased to have useful work.

That evening, I sat in my new room and looked around. I had left Lowood. I had earned the chance to begin again. I did not yet know the people of Thornfield, or the secret the house was keeping.

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6. The house and the stranger

I settled into my work with Adèle. We had lessons each day, and slowly she learned to listen and concentrate. Mrs Fairfax treated me with respect. Thornfield was larger and more comfortable than any home I had known.

But sometimes I heard a strange laugh from the upper part of the house. Mrs Fairfax said it came from a servant, Grace Poole. Her answer did not explain why the sound made me uneasy.

The owner, Mr Rochester, was often away. I wondered what he was like, but I had no reason to expect that meeting him would change my life.

One winter afternoon, I walked along a quiet road to post a letter. The path was icy. I heard a horse behind me, then a sudden noise. The horse had slipped, and its rider had fallen.

I went towards him. He looked angry and was trying to stand.

“Can I help you?” I asked.

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At first, he seemed unwilling to accept help. Then he leaned on me and got back onto his horse. He asked where I lived. When I told him, he looked at me with interest.

I returned to Thornfield after dark. Inside, I learned that Mr Rochester had arrived. Soon I saw the man from the road again.

The stranger I had helped was my employer.

He was not gentle in the way Mrs Fairfax was gentle. He was direct, sometimes impatient and difficult to understand. Yet I found myself wanting to hear what he would say next.

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7. Conversations by the fire

Mr Rochester began to ask me questions about my life. He wanted to know where I had grown up and what I had learned. He also looked at my drawings. I was not used to anyone taking such an interest in my thoughts.

He could be moody. Sometimes he spoke warmly; at other times, he was distant. But when he talked to me honestly, I felt that my ideas mattered.

I did not pretend to agree with everything he said. He seemed to enjoy that.

“You speak plainly, Miss Eyre,” he told me.

“I try to speak the truth,” I answered.

Adèle was the daughter of a French woman he had known. He was paying for her care and education, even though the history of their relationship was painful to him. As he told me more about his past, I began to see a lonely person behind his difficult manner.

One night, I heard the strange laugh again. Then I noticed smoke. I followed it to Mr Rochester's room. His bed curtains were burning.

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I woke him and threw water onto the fire. Together, we put it out.

He thanked me with an intensity I did not expect. Then he went upstairs. When he returned, he did not tell me everything he had discovered.

I thought Grace Poole must be responsible. But if she had started the fire, why was she allowed to stay? The next morning, life at Thornfield continued as if nothing had happened. My questions remained unanswered.

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8. Guests at Thornfield

Mr Rochester invited a group of wealthy people to Thornfield. The house became busy with fine clothes, meals, music and conversation. I watched much of it from the edge of the room.

Among the guests was Blanche Ingram. She was beautiful, confident and used to being admired. People seemed to expect that Mr Rochester would marry her.

I tried to tell myself that this did not matter. He was my employer. I was a governess with no fortune and no important family. Yet I had begun to care for him, and the thought of losing our conversations hurt me.

Blanche did not treat governesses with respect. Listening to her, I understood that having money and good manners did not always mean having kindness.

During the visit, another guest arrived: Richard Mason, who had travelled from Jamaica. When Mr Rochester heard his name, his face changed.

Later that night, a cry woke the house. Mr Rochester told everyone not to worry, but privately he asked me to help

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him. Mr Mason had been hurt in an upstairs room.

I stayed with the injured man while Mr Rochester brought a doctor. I was told not to ask questions. Mr Mason left before the other guests could learn much about the event.

Again, I had been close to a secret without being allowed to understand it. My feelings for Mr Rochester were growing, but so was my confusion. I wished he would trust me with the truth.

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9. News from Gateshead

A message arrived from Gateshead. My aunt was seriously ill and had asked to see me. John Reed had died after years of harmful behaviour and money problems. His death had made his mother's illness worse.

I returned to the house where I had once felt so unwanted. It was strange to walk through the familiar rooms as an adult. I was no longer the child who had been locked in the red room.

Eliza and Georgiana had grown apart. Each had plans for her own future. I tried to help where I could, but my aunt remained difficult to reach.

Before she died, she showed me a letter from my uncle, John Eyre. He lived in Madeira and had wanted to find me. He had hoped to care for me and leave me his money.

My aunt had replied that I was dead.

For a moment, I could hardly speak. A different life had been possible, and she had hidden it from me.

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I told her that I could forgive her. I wanted peace between us. But forgiveness did not make us close, and she did not become the loving aunt I had once needed.

After her death, I prepared to leave Gateshead again. I had come back because it was the right thing to do, not because the house had become my home.

I found myself thinking of Thornfield. I missed Adèle and Mrs Fairfax. Most of all, I missed Mr Rochester. I was beginning to understand where my heart had gone.

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10. Under the chestnut tree

When I returned to Thornfield, I felt happy to see Mr Rochester. But he soon told me that he would marry Blanche Ingram. If that happened, he said, I would have to leave and take a position far away.

The thought broke through the careful walls I had built around my feelings. One evening in the garden, I told him how much leaving would hurt me.

I was poor, but I was not without a heart. I could feel love and pain as deeply as anyone with a great name or a large fortune.

Mr Rochester listened. Then he told me that he did not intend to marry Blanche. He wanted to marry me.

At first, I could not believe him. I thought he might be making fun of me. But he spoke seriously. He said that he loved me.

I said yes.

For a little while, I allowed myself to imagine a future full of happiness. Yet I did not want marriage to turn me into someone I did not recognise. When he offered expensive

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presents, I felt uncomfortable. I wanted affection and respect, not a new identity bought with jewels.

That night, a storm struck the old chestnut tree near the place where we had spoken. Lightning split it in two.

I heard the news the next morning. I tried not to attach meaning to it. I was loved, and I was going to marry. Still, a small part of me remained uneasy, as if happiness were standing beside something I could not yet see.

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11. The torn veil

The days before the wedding were full of plans. Mr Rochester wanted everything to happen quickly. Mrs Fairfax seemed surprised by our engagement and urged me to be careful.

I wrote to my uncle in Madeira. I told him that I was alive and that I was going to marry Mr Rochester. I hoped the letter might begin a relationship that had been kept from us for so long.

But at Thornfield, my sleep became troubled. I had frightening dreams about being separated from the man I loved.

Then, one night, I woke and saw a woman in my room.

She was not Grace Poole. She looked at my wedding veil, lifted it and tore it. I was too frightened to call out. Before leaving, she came close enough for me to see her face clearly.

When I told Mr Rochester, he tried to explain it away. He suggested that the strange experience belonged partly to a dream. But the torn veil was real.

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I wanted to believe him. I wanted our wedding day to arrive and end the uncertainty. Yet I could not forget the woman in my room.

The morning of the wedding was quiet. I dressed simply. Mr Rochester was impatient to leave for the church. We walked together, and I tried to keep my mind on the life that was about to begin.

I did not know that a letter, a stranger and a hidden marriage were already on their way to stop us.

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12. The truth upstairs

We stood in the church while the wedding began. Then a man spoke and said that the marriage could not take place.

Mr Rochester already had a wife.

At first, the words seemed impossible. The man was a lawyer called Mr Briggs. Richard Mason was with him. Mason explained that his sister, Bertha, had married Mr Rochester years earlier in Jamaica. She was still alive.

Mr Rochester did not deny it. He took us back to Thornfield and led us upstairs.

There, I saw the woman who had torn my veil. Bertha was seriously ill. Grace Poole had been paid to care for her and watch over her in the upper rooms. The fire and the cries I had heard were connected to this hidden life.

Everything I had believed about my future changed in a single morning.

Later, Mr Rochester explained his unhappy marriage and the circumstances that had brought him to Jamaica. He said that he had wanted a different life with me. He

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asked me to stay with him, even though we could not marry as planned.

I loved him. That was what made my answer so painful.

But love could not make the truth disappear. He had allowed me to prepare for a marriage without telling me that it was impossible. I could not begin a life by ignoring my own judgement and values.

I needed to leave. If I stayed and listened to him for much longer, I feared I would lose the strength to go.

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13. The road away

Before the house woke, I left Thornfield. I carried very little. I had no clear destination and nobody waiting for me.

The journey used up my money. When I stepped down from the coach, I realised that I had left my small parcel behind. I was alone in an unfamiliar place with almost nothing.

For several days, I walked, asked for work and tried to find food. People did not know my story. To them, I was a stranger whose clothes and tired face raised questions they did not want to answer.

I slept outdoors. I became weak with hunger. Once, I had imagined that leaving would be painful but simple. Now I understood how quickly a person without money or help could become helpless.

At last, I reached a house on the moor. Through a window, I saw a warm room and two young women. I knocked.

The servant at first refused to let me in. I tried to explain

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that I could walk no further. My voice was weak, and I was close to falling.

Then a young man appeared. He saw that I needed help and let me enter.

His name was St John Rivers. He lived with his sisters, Diana and Mary. They gave me food, warmth and a bed. I told them that my name was Jane Elliott because I did not yet feel ready to tell the whole truth.

Their kindness did not ask me to prove that I deserved to survive.

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14. A small school and a new beginning

It took time for my strength to return. Diana and Mary were intelligent and warm. We read and talked together. With them, I began to feel the easy companionship I had wanted for so much of my life.

St John was different. He was serious and deeply committed to the work he believed he should do. He was preparing to travel to India as a missionary. He wanted to live according to duty, even when duty made him unhappy.

He helped me find work teaching at a village school. The room was small, and my pupils had not had the advantages of wealthy children. At first, my new life felt far from Thornfield.

But the children needed an education. I learned to notice their abilities and to take pride in their progress. Useful work helped me stand on my own feet again.

I still thought of Mr Rochester. Sometimes I imagined his voice so clearly that I had to stop what I was doing. I

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wondered whether he was safe and whether he had forgiven me for leaving.

Yet I did not return. I had made a difficult choice, and I needed to build a life that I could respect.

Diana and Mary had to leave for work. I missed them, but the house and the school had given me something important. I had survived the road away from Thornfield. I could earn my living. Even when I was lonely, I was not without a future.

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15. A name and an inheritance

St John began to learn more about me. A small piece of writing helped him connect my real name with news he had received from a lawyer.

“Your name is Jane Eyre,” he told me.

I knew then that I could not continue hiding behind the name Jane Elliott.

My uncle in Madeira had died. He had left me a large fortune: twenty thousand pounds. The lawyer, Mr Briggs, had been trying to find me.

I was astonished by the money. But St John's next explanation mattered even more.

Diana, Mary and St John were my cousins. We were connected through the family of my uncle, John Eyre. The people who had helped me when I had nothing were my own family.

For years, I had thought I belonged to nobody. Now I had relatives I could love.

My uncle had left his money to me, not to the Rivers

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family. But keeping all of it did not feel right. I wanted to share it equally between the four of us.

St John questioned my decision. I did not change my mind. Five thousand pounds each would give all of us independence. The money would let Diana and Mary come home instead of working far away.

Being rich was a new experience. Having a family was a greater happiness.

At last, I did not have to choose between being useful and being loved. I could imagine a home built on shared kindness rather than a debt I was always expected to repay.

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16. A different proposal

St John wanted me to go to India with him. He believed I could help with his work. Then he asked me to become his wife.

He did not speak as Mr Rochester had spoken. This was not a proposal of love. St John believed that I had the right qualities for a life of duty beside him.

I respected his courage and his determination. I was willing to help him in ways I could manage. But I knew that marriage without love would slowly make me unhappy.

I offered to go as a companion in the work, like a sister. He refused. In his view, I must become his wife or stay behind.

His certainty made it hard for me to trust my own feelings. He spoke as if accepting him were the only good and generous choice. For a time, I almost allowed his strong will to become my decision.

Then I seemed to hear my name called across a great distance.

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“Jane! Jane! Jane!”

It sounded like Mr Rochester's voice. I could not explain the experience. Whether it came from memory, longing or something beyond my understanding, it broke the pressure of that moment.

I needed to know what had happened to him.

I told St John that I must make my own choice. His purpose was not automatically my purpose. I could care about him without agreeing to become his wife.

Soon, I began the journey back towards Thornfield. This time, I was not a poor governess returning to an employer. I was an independent woman searching for the truth.

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17. What remained of Thornfield

I travelled with a heart full of questions. I had written without receiving the news I needed. I did not know if Mr Rochester was still at Thornfield or if he had gone away.

When I reached the house, I stopped in shock.

Thornfield Hall had burned. The windows were empty, and the walls were damaged. The house where I had taught Adèle, spoken beside the fire and prepared for my wedding was now a ruin.

A man nearby told me what had happened.

Bertha had escaped from the rooms where she was being watched and set fire to the house. Mr Rochester had helped the people inside get out. He had then tried to save his wife.

She had reached the roof. He could not bring her to safety. She fell and died.

While trying to leave the burning house, he was badly injured. He had lost a hand and his sight. He now lived quietly at another house called Ferndean.

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I listened carefully. The story was terrible, and I was sorry for the suffering it held. Bertha's life and death were not simply the removal of a difficulty from mine. A person had been lost, and others had been changed for ever.

But Mr Rochester was alive.

I did not turn back. I asked how to reach Ferndean and prepared to go there. Whatever I found, I wanted to meet him honestly, with nothing hidden between us. I had come too far to be afraid of the truth now.

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18. Finding him again

Ferndean stood in a quiet place among trees. When I arrived, I saw Mr Rochester outside. He moved carefully and held out his hand to feel what was near him.

I watched for a moment. Then I entered the house.

Later, when I brought him a drink, he heard my voice. At first, he thought his longing had made him imagine me.

“Jane?” he said.

“Yes. I am here.”

He reached for me. I took his hand and let him know that I was real.

We talked for a long time. I told him where I had been and how Diana, Mary and St John had helped me. I told him about my inheritance and the family I had found.

I was no longer dependent on him for money or a home. I had people who cared for me. I had returned because I chose to return.

He worried that pity had brought me back. I explained that I loved him. Caring about what had happened to

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him did not cancel that love.

He had changed too. His loss had made him less certain that he could control life or arrange it according to his wishes. This time, he did not ask me to forget the truth or give up my judgement.

The future could not be the one we had once imagined. Yet something more honest was possible. We could speak as two people who had suffered, learned and chosen each other with open eyes.

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19. A life I chose

Mr Rochester asked me to marry him again. This time, there was no hidden marriage to stop us and no secret that took away my right to choose.

I said yes.

We married quietly. I did not need a grand wedding or expensive clothes to make the day important. I wanted a shared life in which I could love without losing myself.

At Ferndean, we built that life slowly. I helped him see the world through my descriptions, but our relationship was not made only of help and need. We talked, laughed and understood one another. I had something to give, and so did he.

After some time, a little sight returned to one of his eyes. When our son was born, he could see the child. His happiness in that moment was a happiness I shared.

I stayed close to Diana and Mary. They made lives of their own, and our family remained a source of joy. St John went to India and followed the path he had chosen. It was not my path, and I no longer felt guilty for

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knowing that.

When I think of the child behind the curtain at Gateshead, I wish I could tell her that her life would grow larger. There would be pain, but there would also be friendship, work, family and love.

I did not find peace by becoming silent or by accepting every life that someone else chose for me. I found it by learning to speak, to leave when I needed to, and to return when the choice was truly mine.

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Words to keep

Governess: a woman employed to teach children in their home.

Orphan: a child whose parents have died.

Housekeeper: a person who manages the daily work of a home.

Accusation: a statement that someone has done something wrong.

Fortune: a large amount of money or valuable property.

Inheritance: money or property received from someone who has died.

Independent: able to make your own choices and support yourself.

Proposal: a request to marry someone; also a suggested plan.

Duty: something you believe you should do because it is right or necessary.

Companion: someone who spends time with another person.

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Judgement: the ability to think carefully and decide what is right.

Respect: treating another person's feelings, choices and rights as important.

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After the story

Which person gave Jane the kind of help she needed most? Choose one moment from the story and explain your answer.

Jane leaves two situations because the life being offered does not feel right for her. What does she gain by trusting her own judgement?

Try telling the story in five sentences. Then choose three expressions from this version and use them to describe an experience of your own.

This is an original simplified adaptation of a public-domain novel. It is not Charlotte Brontë's complete text. The original remains available beside this version in Culture Corner.

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